IMPLICIT BIAS AND THE CROSS-RACE EFFECT

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Abstract: The present study replicated the Cross-Race Effect (CRE) phenomenon and examined the influence of high levels of knowledge about the Trayvon Martin shooting in Florida on the robustness of the CRE. Study 1 used White and Black photos in a face recognition paradigm and Study 2 was an online-based survey assessing the influence of media exposure to the Trayvon Martin shooting on participants' cross-race face identification accuracy. Results indicate that participants were more accurate in their identification of White than Black faces for all accuracy indicators (p<.001), thus replicating the CRE. However, the magnitude of the CRE wanes as a function of actual and self-reported knowledge. Actual and self-reported knowledge of the shooting did influence discrimination accuracy of White and Black faces (p<.001). Studies 1 and 2 suggest that the CRE is generally a robust phenomenon and eyewitness evidence for cross-racial identification remains vulnerable to error.

Introduction

• The Cross Race Effect (CRE) is the tendency for individuals to better recognize same-race faces than other-race faces (Hugenberg et al., 2010; Meissener & Brigham, 2001).

• Eyewitness testimony is susceptible to error insofar as implicit attitudes and the CRE can influence the perceptions, interactions, judgments, and discriminations of other races. Consequently, these processes may increase wrongful convictions (Greenwald et al., 2009; Levinson, Young, & Rudman, 2012; Wells et al., 2006).

Hypothesis

Study 1

Individuals with implicit biases will be less accurate in recognizing other-race faces due to a lack of expertise, contact with other races, and motivation to individuate other-race faces.

Study 2

Participants who are informed about the Trayvon Martin shooting will be more aware and sensitive about their responses, enhancing their cross-face discrimination accuracy in Study 1. This might suggest that the CRE is less stable that prior research suggests, and may be attenuated by exposure to racially infused current events.

Significance of Study

Study 1

Investigates the relation between implicit/explicit racial attitudes and cross-race face recognition/identification.

Study 2

Examines whether exposure to media coverage of the Trayvon Martin shooting influenced the data collected in Study 1, such that it will attenuate the CRE.

Methods

Study 1

Participants were 54 University of Minnesota undergraduate students (50% male, 47% female, 3% unreported). The average age of participants was 19.92 years (SD = 2.895, 1 not reported).

• Day 1: participants took an online survey measuring the race Implicit Association Test, Symbolic Racism, contact with other races, and motivation to control prejudiced reactions.

• Day 2: participants distinguished between 25 old and new African American and White male faces, all between the ages of 20-30. Participants then distinguished between target and novel photos from a line-up of 12 photos for each race.

Study 2

Participants were 34 (63%) of the University of Minnesota students who completed Study 1.

A survey was administered via email to collect additional information assessing exposure to media coverage of the Trayvon Martin shooting in Florida on cross-face discrimination accuracy through knowledge and judgments about the case.

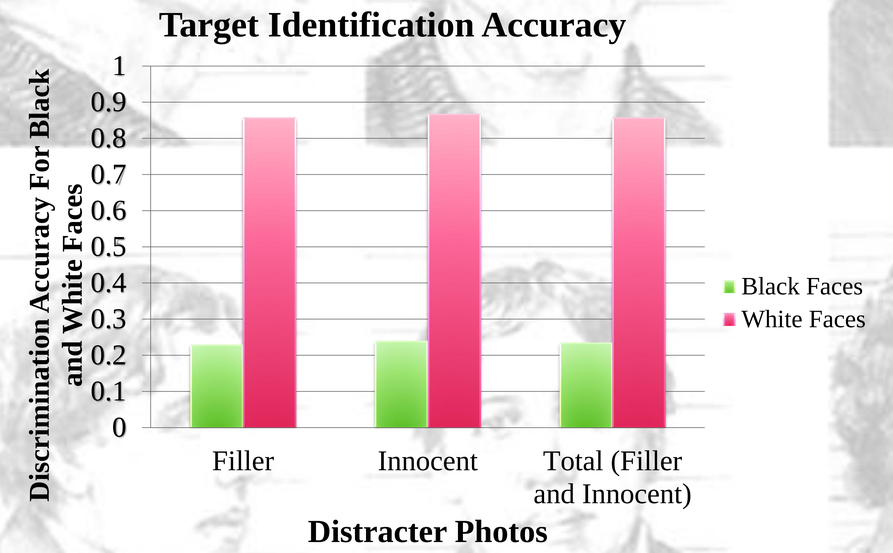


Figure 1: Participants' discrimination accuracy in target photo identification among filler and innocent photos for African American and White faces (Study 1).

Discussion

Study 1

Participants' discrimination accuracy was better for White faces than Black faces across all accuracy indicators (p<.001).

Study 2

Self-reported knowledge and actual knowledge regarding the Trayvon Martin event did affect participants' discrimination accuracy for Black and White faces (p=.05) and illustrated the CRE for different reasons.

High actual knowledge led to higher accuracy for white faces (p<.001) while high self-reported knowledge exhibited lower accuracy for Black faces (p<.001).

It is possible that the motivation to process information as well as the level of actual and self-reported knowledge regarding the case facts influences accuracy. The data, however, do not address the exact process by which this influence might occur.

Implications

The magnitude of the CRE is a generally robust psychological process, but it wanes depending on knowledge of racially salient media events.

This raises the need for a reconsideration of the reliance on eyewitness identification testimonies in criminal cases as CRE has the potential to result in misidentifications and false convictions of other-race members (Wells et al., 2006).

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